



“Technology has helped us in providing better services in a cost effective manner. However, the focus also needs to be on process improvement, simplification, standardization etc. and not just on computerization. Before computerization, question needs to be asked if the process is needed at all and can it be eliminated instead of being computerized.”

lakhs and e-Office for internal office automation and file management. This has further enhanced speed and efficiency in functioning of the State Government.”

Mr Aggarwal's quick to point out that there is full political support for introducing enhanced IT practices and policies in government services, and being the Secretary IT of the State, he has been given a free hand to ideate and conceptualize new projects and initiatives. “There haven't been any significant challenges while ideating new projects. We have

introduced new concepts like Virtual IT Cadre, Tech Saturday training program, online e-Governance training and certification program etc. for capacity building. We have also taken lead in setting up a Government cloud, IPV6 implementation etc,” says Mr Aggarwal.

Mr Aggarwal also highlighted the fact that many of the applications developed by the State of Maharashtra are being shared with other states for adoption. “Source codes have been shared with other State Governments so

that they may benefit from the application development work undertaken by us. For example, the UID linked SADM application has been appreciated by Government of India and the source code has been shared with all State Governments for their use. We have offered our Android based application for audit and survey to various other states on cloud. We have been pushing for sharing of source code with all Government entities to ensure optimal usage of taxpayers' money.”

The magic of electricity... in every home in India

We all know that with great power comes great responsibility. But never has power been as wantonly abused as it is here in India. Much as we'd like to talk about the corridors of power inside government institutions, we'd like to stick to electricity (or power, as it's generally referred to here in India) for the purpose of this article. Every year, around US \$30 billion worth of electricity is wasted in India – primarily due to theft and pilferage. That's about 185.6 lakh crore rupees. That's roughly 80 per cent of our country's defence spending for the year, 12 times the annual budget of the Ministry of Drinking Water and Sanitation, and six times the budget assigned for the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare.

While all this is happening in the

country's power sector, 77 million households in India don't have access to a basic resource that we city slickers take for granted. This is where Yashraj Khaitan, the co-founder and CEO of Gram Power, is trying to remedy the situation and bring in accountability. Khaitan claims that the effective use of technology and innovative business models can reduce electricity losses on the National Grid by an amount which can be used to electrify the entire nation within three years.

So what is Gram Power?

“It's simplest explanations would be its analogy to cell phones, I guess,” explains Yashraj. “Where everybody is privy to how they use prepaid cell phones, and they are also aware of the advantages

that a prepaid cell phone brings to them. So the main advantage that GP brings is that it just allows them to essentially get a lot of control on their electricity bills. It allows them to purchase power in an easy, transparent and affordable manner. And it ends up giving, just as your cell phone gives you, connectivity on demand. Also the reliability that we end up bringing to the entire infrastructure allows the consumer to get power on demand.”

This is a far cry from what we're used to on the existing grid, which we have to supply power in our homes where electricity and its consumption is difficult to understand and analyze.

There are essentially two models of electrification that Gram Power delivers: One is the smart microgrid that they set for villages that are completely off